

Grace Cannot Be Earned

This morning I told you about a verse. The only one I quoted it to was Tim. I said, "Tim, I have a verse. I am trying to understand it."

I tried to pass it off to the chapter following the verse, which is Solomon's reign, all the victory he had, and the wisdom. I thought, "That first part is not for me. The verse just showed me where He wanted me to begin reading." The part said, "And David slept with his fathers." I wanted to go on to the son's reign. That one was mine, not the other one.

Anyway, I quoted it to Tim. He looked as bewildered as I did. I tried to explain it away, but I did not catch the meaning until I came out of this, because God was preparing me for it.

I waited a long time for this day when I would be this close to the end. I am not leaving the planet. That is not the one that is dying. I cannot tell you how excited I am to be close enough to know that, unless I die, it is going to make a tradeoff: I get Him, and He gets the rest of me.

How many have ever heard a place like this talked about? It is here. I thought that was where revival was. How many have ever been in a real revival and seen it change a city? I thought that was where revival was.

Maybe our generation, and maybe a lot of people, have not visited that place.

Does the word desperate mean anything?

Let me tell you about God's grace. You have no more chance of working for any of it than you do of not dying. It is inevitable. We may not all sleep if we are here at the moment of change, but nobody escapes this body.

Flesh and blood cannot enter the kingdom of God. This body is not going over with me, whether the trumpet blows after I am down or while I am standing here. Everybody faces that.

You have no more chance of earning anything than you do of not dying. Something like this can never be earned. If it could, our strong people with their own ambitions would get it.

Yet this place is so precious. Every unreachable place human beings can attain to did not belong to our fallen state. Every place in God, everything that is or ever will be, has been redeemed for us by this Man, Jesus.

To approach a place like that with anything but yourself is about the cheapest thing a person can do.

When you live your life in the knowledge of grace but do not see His standing strongly in the things He declared to set you free from, sometimes those things hang around and hang on.

We know what the Word says about this position. We know the mystery of faith laid out by everyone who tries to understand that this holy place is attainable only by faith. Yet sometimes we see so little absolute invasion into the supernatural realm that we wonder if we are missing something, or why we cannot attain to something free more freely than we have.

I cannot stand there, look at this bright place, and know that everything has been delivered into the Father's hands through grace, and not go swimming in it.

Come on. This is a place of grace where you can go into a city like Jesus walked in triumphant, knowing who He was and knowing who His Father was.

Why do you think the last person in the line of priests baptized Jesus? Because the law and prophets were until John. John had to baptize Him.

Some theologians say Jesus' body was being prepared to be offered, and that is what the baptism was. Then why was John baptizing other people?

Jesus had to be baptized into our death. That is what the priest did. That is why He had to wait until after that baptism to be filled with the Holy Spirit. In order for Him to walk and preach in the power and authority of the kingdom, He was baptized into our death, and later we were baptized into His.

His baptism was a shadow and type of the death of His own crucifixion that would take place three years later. But it gave Him what He needed to walk in the authority of the kingdom of God.

The law and prophets were until John. Since that time, the kingdom of God is preached, and every man presses into it.

That is what gave the first Man born spiritually alive on this planet the right to receive the same Holy Spirit we received after His baptism. That was the origin of the power He ministered in. He came into the city with the same One living in you. He had the same limitations you do as a man. The difference was that He was baptized into our death so later we could be baptized into His.

Hallelujah.

Can you see that grace? What is it looking for? How about the closest children's hospital? "I need a lot of little human beings born in a state of innocence, because I have Someone with Me who wants to see them. I have Someone with Me who wants their parents to know not only how much He loves those children, but how much He loves the parents."

Jesus had a way of stopping funeral processions.

We have a place called done. We have a place of grace so sacred that trying to attain it and hand it to yourself cheapens even the thought of it. That happens if you think some shiny thing you have done can ever replace His operation of grace.

I am finding out that I truly was created unto good works. Make no mistake: good works did not create me. I was created for them.

God loves you so much. Do you think He wants you circling the perimeter of grace?

You know what is wrong with chocolate pie? The taste. You cannot just taste it.

You know what is wrong with grace? You cannot just taste it.

The people I have known who were suddenly used by grace came back babbling like they fell off a cliff. "I do not understand it. He just came. I did not pray. I did not do anything. He just came."

Then somebody says, "So God does not want us praying or anything. That is the way I lean to grace. I make sure I do not pray. I put big earrings in my ears just to make everybody know I am free."

He loves you so much. When you are having trouble operating in something that is yours, He loves you so much that He gives you keys. He gives you keys that can help you get to something you possibly do not understand.

Keys like praying in tongues, the revelation gift.

Keys like private worship, the all-inclusive presence gift. It first baptizes your spirit wall to wall. Then your senses get dosed in it, a baptism of senses. Then it goes for geography. You cannot even get on the phone or walk into a meeting and say something without God being there to begin doing it. Private worship is the presence gift.

Then there is fasting. When you get too big for your britches, fasting brings rampant, running-ahead flesh back under subjection and subordination to the operation of your spirit. It brings things back into perspective.

Even when you cannot reach out and grab something so free that it eludes your understanding, He gave you keys that can position you from where you are to where He said you can be.

When you are suspended out there in the Spirit, listening and worshipping, a picture forms from nowhere inside. You see it, and you know it did not come from your mind. As far as a revelation gift goes, you suddenly understand something you have been reaching for.

I saw myself waist deep in unanswered prayer. I was trying everything I knew. It was not that I was not learned. I have been taught some by the Holy Spirit. I was using what I knew.

I combined this "in Jesus' name." Maybe I should loose it. I loose this. Maybe I should fast until it goes away. Maybe I should speak to it. "You prayers, get answered."

I thank God for the building blocks. I thank God for all those things. I get more prayers answered than most. But there were some I was swimming in unanswered, waist deep.

I was trying everything normal, everything that had worked before, until I hit one of those things we call an impasse. When people in prayer hit certain things, either they take it out or it takes them out. That is an impasse: a place you have been before and never gotten past.

What are you going to do? Stand there and fight, or turn back again?

Then I saw grace come. This is about the only way I can explain it. Before the eternities of time, He had this place for me. He had one for you. He positioned being and place.

I understand much about it now. He has called me to doctrine, because of the age I live in, media, and many things. You have heard me talk about it. I came home to find out these things.

Here is this place, from the foundation of the world, for me, like you. In the sovereign attribute God possesses, you have to understand this about Him: does He know what I will be doing ten years from now, down to the minute? Yes, He does. He absolutely has that capability. After all, He is God.

How will He know? This is the miracle of it: He knows what it will be, even though it is up to me what it will be.

You can say, "How can He do that?"

He is God. He can calculate to the end of your life at the end of each thought, before you can think the next one.

"What if I married Taffy instead of Candy?"

"You would be doing this."

"What if I married Susie?"

"You would be doing this."

He knows.

Recently a friend of mine lost a blood brother. He burned in a fire. She had been trying to get him saved and believing for him for some time. As far as she knew, she had no news at the time of his death except how he was. But God made sure she knew.

The chaplain of the fire department came and told her what a neighbor had told him: for the last week or so, her brother had been over to the neighbor several times talking about God, and he had gotten born again.

Of course, part of her question was, "If he just got saved, why did he die in the fire?"

I said, "Listen to me. If God could have saved him from the fire, He would have. But He could not because He could not find enough to save him with from the fire."

How could that be?

God has the power to run a check on you with the last thoughts you had. If He saw him in hell later, it would tie God's hands, and He would not have a chance in the world to get him out then.

The way God causes change in our lives is that He moves on people. People come to us and introduce systems of thought that receive God. God will keep checking and coming back until He has you secure. He will keep sending people and sending them.

Just because one day He drops them off in a place called done.

There is one thing He will not do: go on to heaven without them.

Let us talk about this place He has for me. Here it is. He provided it for me.

Hallelujah.

Obviously cities are saved there, because I am crazy over it. I cannot go on without putting the salvation of cities in there. I cannot do it. I do not have to live without it anymore.

Give me cities lest I die.

You do not have to live without it anymore.

What He has for me is there.

But here I am, stuck waist deep in prayers that are not being answered. All of this is there, and I want to go there. So I keep talking to the stuff here: "Leave me alone. If you do not turn loose of my rib, I am going to deal with you. Who has my feet? Turn loose of my feet. I want to go on."

He repositioned my believing.

You talk about grace for prayer. It is no problem for me now to go to that new place He has for me, stretch myself out there, worship God, thank Him, and pray like a house on fire, knowing I am there and those things cannot hold me down.

He did the classic grace thing with me: "Go twenty-five feet that way. Now look at the people."

When I fell in the hole and crawled out, I saw this place. I received grace for it. Glory to God. My faith went there. I started worshiping Him and believing, and everything became there.

The problem was that I was still waist deep over here. So God came by grace. I did not earn a penny of it. He took my spirit and positioned it over there in the place called done. Then He came back and got the rest of me and walked me out of it with a prayer from there, a prayer life from there.

The mud turned loose.

Did fasting help? Yes. It positioned my old man so well that I could see the mud. What did it do to my spirit? My spirit did not want to stay there. What happened to the rest of me? It went over there.

What place are you praying out of? A place called done.

I know that I know that I know.

Paul said:

I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus.

Was the high calling apostolic? No. God will attach Himself to a person with diversities of tongues who has not even prayed his way into governments or helps. It was not merely apostolic.

Entering into that verse in Philippians 3, Paul said:

That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection.

He said, "I count all things but dung."

Being a Pharisee of Pharisees, concerning the law blameless, did not mean he did not have a nature of sin. It meant that when there was a crossing of the law, he had a sacrifice, a purification time, a feast day. Paul was diligence personified. His zeal even reached to the killing of believers, with letters from the high priest on the road to Damascus.

Stephen's intercession at death intercepted Paul and knocked him to the ground. He wanted to know who it was, and Jesus said, "I am He whom you persecute."

This man loved God with all the devil that was in him. God reached down and got him. He got someone who never looked back.

Paul said:

That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection, and the fellowship of his sufferings.

He wanted to know Him, being made conformable to His death, if by any means he might attain to the out-resurrection from among the dead.

Was Paul saying he wanted to get beaten, imprisoned, and marooned? No, even though sometimes that came with the territory and they glorified God for being counted worthy to suffer shame for His name.

The fellowship of His sufferings means Paul wanted to know by revelation every single thing Jesus suffered and died under: the penalty of your sicknesses and diseases, the righteousness that came from Him being made sin, and the peace He left us that is not of this world.

Paul wanted to be so made conformable to His death, in the fellowship of His sufferings, that if by any means he might attain to an out-resurrection from among the dead before the actual resurrection. In that, he pressed toward the mark for the prize of the high call in Christ Jesus.

He was talking about attaining total conformity to all the things Jesus died under, so that he himself could minister in the power of those things Jesus paid such a horrible price for.

Private worship is one of those keys. It seems to be the conduit that causes the love of God to flow from His Spirit to mine. The part of me that has the capacity to pool or reservoir the unlimited capacity for the love of God is my new nature, which made me a partaker of His divine nature.

The more He pours that love in my spirit, the more I understand. I have already been through that season of trying to get Him to love me more, which was impossible. At the time, I did not understand that.

No matter how hard I tried, I could not get Him to love me any more than He already does, because His love was maxed for me the day He laid my penalty on Jesus. It is impossible for Him to love me more.

He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how shall he not with him also freely give us all things?

He is not asking you to give Him a reason why He will. He is asking you to come up with one reason on His part why He will not do this for you.

I have already spent my season trying to get Him to love me. It is impossible. He cannot love me more than He already does. The love was manifested on the cross. However, I have found out how to park myself and start receiving the love He has already loved me with from the beginning.

One of those conduits is private worship, which causes the free flow of His love to mine.

If you do not think it affects you, look at this quivering mass of protoplasmic flesh here. Could anyone here possibly be having as good a time as I am?

Are you understanding that place called done better? Once you start positioning yourself there, you get rid of the doubt, the accusations, the hardness of heart, and the blaming of God.

You can talk the language out, but your heart may still be blaming Him: "He could have done something if He wanted to."

No, He could not, or He would have. He loves you.

When you get all that off you and start positioning yourself in a place called done, your worship, talking, praying, acting, and walking all speak from a place where something inside says, "I have it, and I know I do."

Do not think I do not ask Him to help me teach this more slowly. It may take a lot more fasting to lose my humor.

Climbing out of that hole, I taught my soul to say, "All is well. All is well with my soul."

There are no prayers Jesus prayed that were not answered. In the Garden of Gethsemane, when He presented His hardest prayer, His sweat was as great drops of blood. The agony was comparable to the place where you cannot go on from. His humanity was being offered with all sight, hearing, feeling, and emotion.

God could not help Him. He separated Himself from Him. Jesus was in the Father, the Father was in Him, and He was there as an individual, but His part could be separated without changing Him. He cried, "My God, My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?"

Do you think He had a choice? He had to do it.

One thing is sure: God help anything or anybody that tries to separate you from Him, because Jesus paid a price so nothing would ever have the power to do that.

Jesus prayed, "If it be possible..." In other words, "If there is any other way You can save humanity, please take that course. Let this cup pass from Me. Nevertheless..."

God looked beyond. He loved humanity, and Jesus loved them. Ten billion equations later, there was no other way.

You bow down before Him today because He loved you. He loved you. He loved you.

Now He has given you His glory:

My glory I give unto you.

He said this so you may know the Father loves you every bit as much as He loved Him.

You do not have to be afraid. Principalities, powers, death: nothing has the power to separate you from the love of God in Christ Jesus. Nothing can separate you from what is yours, from the health He has for you, or from the blessing.

Always keep this in mind: the engine that powers your ministry will be the one that never quits reaching for souls.